

The Missing Theme



We are into an election dominated by holograms and hollow men, and I have no intention to be yet another exhausted politics-weary, non-voting harrumph when all the good men are supposed to join in the noble cause of redeeming the nation from the rascals in starched cotton or patterned saffron. The movement in the arena, though, is an underwhelming experience. The chief antagonists, both designated prime ministerial candidates, seem to have finally acknowledged each other. In the suddenly hurtful narrative style perfected by them, the gentleman who wants to keep his job and the residency at 7 Race Course Road is the "weakest" prime minister and his challenger, a nationalist hardened by his struggle against power, is the man who has "demolished" the edifice of secular India. L.K. Advani, the longest surviving *yatri* of Indian politics who for the first time sees the distance between his destination and destiny shrinking, wants to be more than the strong leader of this stoic democracy. He wants to engage the "weakling" in a direct combat, presidential style, with a few television debates thrown in. Manmohan Singh, the prime minister who is not the prime mover in the politics of this country or in the affairs of his party, is not a man of the masses. A perfect blend of the pedagogical and the bureaucratic, he is more expressive in focus groups. Ideally, he, not Advani, should be the candidate asking for a television debate. Such a conversation would have brought India closer to the two men fighting for it. The choice should be between these two for one explicit reason: the rest in the fray stand for a hundred Indias, and their vision doesn't break the boundaries of a panchayat.

What we miss in the campaign polyphony is the voice that captures the zeitgeist. Both the "weakest" and the "strongest" are today busy with defending their reputations. But reputations are anyway fallible in a campaign driven by personalities. Well, there is a plot, and there are characters who represent every instinct—the best and the worst—in politics. Where is the theme? It is out there, orphaned and abandoned by the men who want to rule India. Forget the manifestos. They are screeds of platitudes and promises, a hastily constructed utopia to be sold at the press conference. The theme should be there in the stump speeches, on the airwaves, in the drawing rooms. An election should be a national argument, and this is not an election held in normal times. The two great themes of the times—economy and the terror of radical Islam—are absent from the narrative of this election, which happens to be just another show in politics-as-usual. Let's have a direct debate between the Significant Two and see who is in the danger of missing a piece of history.



SAURABH SINGH

WHAT WE MISS IN THE CAMPAIGN POLYPHONY IS THE VOICE THAT CAPTURES THE ZEITGEIST. AN ELECTION SHOULD BE A NATIONAL ARGUMENT.

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Filmmaker **Shakti Samanta**, who made films like *Howrah Bridge*, *Kashmir Ki Kali*, *An Evening in Paris*, *Aradhana*, *Kati*



Patang and Amar Prem. He was 83.

WON: By the **Indian** hockey team, the Sultan Azlan Shah Cup after 13 years, beating Malaysia 3-1 in Ipoh. This was India's fourth cup win, the earlier ones coming in 1985, 1991 and 1995.

DIED: **Umrao Singh**, 83, president of the Athletics Federation of India and recipient of the Padma Bhushan for his contribution to the 1982 Asian Games. He was a minister in Beant Singh's government in Punjab before becoming a Lok Sabha member.

DIED: Hindi writer **Vishnu Prabhakar**, 97, director in All India Radio from 1955 to 1957, a Padma Bhushan and Sahitya Akademi awardee.

